

Emerging Themes

from

Australia's Financial Frontline

Practice insights from trauma-informed capability building across Australian financial services

“Who supports the people supporting everyone else?”

Practice-based insights from workshops exploring:

- Emotional labour
- Psychological safety
- Compassion fatigue
- Team wellbeing
- Reflective practice



Understanding trauma.
Creating safety.
Enabling wellbeing.



Insights from banking • insurance • financial counselling
customer support and related services

ABOUT THE SERIES

Getting the Most from This Practice Insight

This Practice Insight brings together the voices and reflections of financial services professionals who participated in trauma-informed capability building workshops. It is designed to inform, inspire and support organisations as they strengthen workplace wellbeing, psychological safety and trauma-informed practice across the sector.

IF YOU'RE SHORT ON TIME

Start with the Executive Summary, the Five Emerging Themes and What Organisations Can Do Tomorrow for a fast overview.

WAYS TO USE THIS PUBLICATION

For individual learning, team discussions, leadership planning, or organisational reflection on psychosocial safety.

01 Executive Summary	A high-level overview of the key insights and implications	5
02 About This Practice Insight	Context, methodology and why this matters	7
03 Understanding the Hidden Emotional Load	A model of how emotional labour builds over time	10
04 Emerging Themes	Five recurring practice insights from the workshops	15
05 What These Themes Suggest	Implications for organisations and leaders	40
06 What Organisations Can Do Tomorrow	Five practical, action-focused steps	44
07 A Final Reflection	Bringing the insights together and looking forward	45
08 References	The evidence base behind this Practice Insight	47

A TIPT reminder — *Trauma-informed practice is not a single initiative. It is a way of thinking, leading and working together that strengthens people, teams and the communities we serve.*

FROM THE AUTHOR

Who Supports the People Supporting Everyone Else?

Over the past several years, I have had the privilege of working alongside financial services professionals supporting customers through some of the most challenging moments of their lives. Financial hardship, scams, bereavement, family and domestic violence, elder abuse, financial abuse and business failure are no longer uncommon experiences for many customers seeking assistance. Behind every account, application or complaint is often a person navigating fear, uncertainty or significant loss.

As I worked with organisations across the financial services sector, one question continued to emerge.

“Who supports the people supporting everyone else?”

Much of the conversation surrounding trauma-informed practice rightly focuses on improving outcomes for customers experiencing vulnerability. However, considerably less attention has been given to the employees who hear these stories every day.

Frontline staff, financial counsellors, complaints officers, hardship teams and customer service professionals are often the first people customers turn to during periods of crisis. In many cases, customers disclose deeply personal experiences that extend well beyond the information required to resolve the immediate issue. Stories of abuse, suicide, grief, violence, financial devastation and trauma are frequently shared with employees who have little warning and limited opportunity to prepare themselves emotionally for what they are about to hear.

While these conversations often occur because customers are searching for understanding, they can also place significant emotional demands on the people listening. We rarely know what experiences our colleagues have lived through themselves. A seemingly routine customer interaction may unexpectedly resonate with an employee's own history of trauma, grief or loss. Even when this is not the case, repeatedly hearing distressing stories while maintaining professionalism, empathy and emotional regulation require considerable psychological effort, which is often not fully considered when organisations set KPIs for their staff.

Financial services professionals are also regularly required to de-escalate highly emotional conversations. Customers experiencing acute stress or trauma may struggle with emotional regulation, become frustrated, frightened or angry, or express feelings of hopelessness and despair. Employees are expected to remain calm, compassionate and solution-focused while managing these interactions, often several times each day. Over time, this emotional labour may contribute to

compassion fatigue, burnout, vicarious trauma and other psychosocial hazards if appropriate organisational supports are not in place.

This does not suggest that financial services organisations are failing their people. In fact, I have been consistently impressed by the compassion, professionalism and commitment demonstrated by those working across the sector. Rather, it highlights an important opportunity to strengthen how organisations support the wellbeing of the people delivering that care.

The capability-building workshops described throughout this publication were developed using the **TIPT Trauma-Informed Framework™**, which applies trauma-informed principles to organisational capability, leadership and workplace practice. While the original purpose of these workshops was to strengthen trauma-informed responses to customers, something unexpected began to emerge. Through facilitated reflection and LEGO® Serious Play®, participants openly shared their own workplace experiences, revealing common themes that extended beyond customer interactions to include emotional labour, burnout, psychological safety, workplace culture and the importance of supportive teams.

This Practice Insight shares those recurring observations. It is not intended to present formal research findings or definitive conclusions. Instead, it offers practice-based insights drawn from real conversations with financial services professionals and invites organisations to consider how trauma-informed capability building might support not only vulnerable customers, but also the wellbeing of the people who support them every day.

I hope the themes presented throughout this publication contribute to ongoing conversations about trauma-informed leadership, psychologically safer workplaces and sustainable approaches to supporting those working at the frontline of Australia's financial services sector.

Tanya Hallett

Founder & CEO, TIPT — Trauma Informed Practice Training and Advisory

The observations presented in this publication have also informed the ongoing development of the TIPT Third Space Framework™, a complementary conceptual framework that explores practical mechanisms for operationalising psychologically safer workplace interactions through experiential learning and reflective practice.

01 · EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Executive Summary

Every day across Australia, financial services professionals help people facing financial hardship, family violence, scams, bereavement, business failure and homelessness.

Yet one important question is rarely asked:

“Who supports the people hearing these stories every day?”

While significant progress has been made in strengthening customer vulnerability frameworks and improving service responses, comparatively less attention has been given to the emotional impact this work has on the employees providing that support.

This Practice Insight shares recurring observations emerging from trauma-informed capability-building workshops delivered within the Australian financial services sector. The workshops were designed using the **TIPT Trauma-Informed Framework™**, a practice-based framework that integrates the principles of safety, trust, collaboration, choice, empowerment and cultural responsiveness into organisational capability development. Through experiential learning, facilitated reflection and LEGO® Serious Play®, participants explored the realities of emotionally demanding work and identified practical strategies for supporting both customer outcomes and employee wellbeing.

Rather than presenting formal research findings, this publication draws upon practice-based observations gathered through participant reflections, facilitated discussions, LEGO® Serious Play® activities and post-workshop reports. Across participants, several consistent themes emerged, including emotional exhaustion, the pressure to remain resilient, guilt associated with taking leave, emotional spill-over into personal life, and the importance of psychologically safer workplace conversations. Participants also consistently identified the value of shared reflection, practical wellbeing strategies and opportunities to openly discuss the emotional realities of their work.

Collectively, these observations suggest that trauma-informed capability building extends beyond improving interactions with vulnerable customers. It may also support organisations to strengthen leadership capability, improve team communication, enhance awareness of psychosocial hazards and foster workplace cultures where employees feel better equipped to seek support, reflect on challenging experiences and sustain their wellbeing over time.

This publication does not seek to provide definitive conclusions regarding organisational outcomes. Instead, it contributes practice-based insights from frontline capability-building initiatives and offers leaders, learning and development professionals, human resources practitioners and customer experience teams an opportunity to consider how trauma-informed principles may be applied to strengthen both employee wellbeing and organisational capability within financial services.



TRAUMA IMPACTS PEOPLE AND SYSTEMS

Trauma • Stress • Adversity • Loss • Violence
Discrimination • Neglect • Serious Incidents
Systemic Harm • Long-Term Stress • Injustice

BARRIERS TO TRAUMA INFORMED PRACTICE



Power imbalances and control



High demands and time pressure



Poor relationships and lack of trust



Stigma, judgement and blame



Lack of understanding about trauma



Lack of cultural safety and inclusion



Rigid systems and limited flexibility



TRAUMA INFORMED PRACTICE

Every interaction has the power to heal or re-traumatise. We choose to heal.

THE SIX PILLARS OF TRAUMA INFORMED PRACTICE



SAFETY – Prioritise physical, emotional and psychological safety in every interaction.



TRUST – Build trust through honesty, consistency, transparency and respect.



CHOICE – Empower people with meaningful choice and collaborative decision-making.



COLLABORATION – Partner with people, value their voice and shared expertise.



EMPOWERMENT – Strengthen independence, voice, confidence and self-determination.



CULTURAL SAFETY – Honour culture, identity and lived experience. Act with humility.



UNDERSTAND TRAUMA AND ITS IMPACT

Pecognise how trauma affects the brain, body, behaviour and relationships.



RECOGNISE TRAUMA RESPONSES

Identify stress responses and adjust our approach to reduce re-traumatisation.



RESPOND WITH COMPASSION AND CURIOSITY

Listen, validate and respond with empathy, not judgement.



SUPPORT REGULATION AND COPING

Help people feel safe, calm and connected.



STRENGTHS AND RESILIENCE FOCUS

Build on strengths, hope and capacity for growth.



REFLECT AND CONTINUOUSLY IMPROVE

Reflect on practice and seek feedback to do better.

STRONGER OUTCOMES FOR PEOPLE, TEAMS & ORGANISATIONS



Increased safety and wellbeing



More trust, openness and connection



Better engagement and participation



Stronger relationships and culture



Improved decision making and outcomes



Healing relationships and reduced re-traumatisation



TRAUMA IMPACT BECOMES VISIBLE

People feel safe to share. Needs are recognised. Responses are informed and appropriate.



SAFE, SUPPORTIVE RESPONSES

People feel heard, validated and supported. Trust and connection grow.



HEALING, GROWTH AND RESILIENCE

People recover, rebuild and thrive. Potential is strengthened.



**HEALTHIER PEOPLE • STRONGER TEAMS
COMPASSIONATE SYSTEMS • BETTER OUTCOMES**
Trauma informed practice creates lasting positive change.

When we understand trauma and respond with compassion, we create the conditions for healing, safety and hope.

02 · CONTEXT & METHODOLOGY

About This Practice Insight

The **TIPT Practice Insight Series** has been developed to share practical observations emerging from organisational capability-building initiatives delivered across a range of Australian industries. Unlike traditional research publications, these Practice Insights draw upon real-world facilitation experiences, participant reflections, organisational themes and workshop observations to contribute to professional discussion and ongoing organisational learning.

This publication explores recurring themes emerging from trauma-informed capability-building workshops delivered within the Australian financial services sector. The workshops were designed using the **TIPT Trauma-Informed Framework™**, which applies the principles of safety, trust, collaboration, choice, empowerment and cultural responsiveness to workplace capability development. Through facilitated reflection, experiential learning and LEGO® Serious Play®, participants were encouraged to explore the emotional realities of working with customers experiencing financial hardship, grief, trauma and other complex life circumstances, while also reflecting on the impact this work has on their own wellbeing.

The observations presented in this publication are derived from participant reflections, facilitated discussions, LEGO® Serious Play® activities and post-workshop reports. Rather than evaluating organisational outcomes or measuring the effectiveness of specific interventions, this Practice Insight identifies recurring themes that emerged across participants and considers what these observations may suggest for leaders, organisations and the broader financial services sector.

The purpose of this publication is not to provide definitive conclusions, but to contribute practice-based insights that complement the growing body of evidence surrounding trauma-informed practice, psychosocial safety and employee wellbeing. By documenting common experiences, recurring organisational themes and practical observations from capability-building initiatives, TIPT aims to support ongoing conversations about how financial institutions can better equip their people to navigate emotionally demanding work while maintaining compassionate, psychologically safer and sustainable workplaces.

Importantly, all participant quotations, examples and organisational observations have been de-identified to protect confidentiality. The themes presented throughout this publication should be understood as emerging practice observations rather than formal research findings and are intended to encourage reflection, organisational learning and future research.

Why This Matters

The Australian financial services sector is increasingly required to support customers experiencing some of the most significant challenges of their lives. Financial hardship, mortgage stress, family violence, fraud, bereavement, natural disasters, business failure and serious illness are no longer uncommon circumstances encountered by frontline staff. Whether working in customer service,

hardship, complaints, lending, insurance or financial counselling, employees are often required to engage with individuals experiencing heightened emotional distress while simultaneously balancing operational demands, regulatory requirements and organisational performance expectations.

Considerable progress has been made across the financial services sector in strengthening customer vulnerability frameworks, improving complaint handling practices and recognising the importance of compassionate, person-centred service delivery. These initiatives acknowledge that customers experiencing adversity may communicate, make decisions and respond differently during periods of heightened stress or trauma. As a result, many organisations have invested in developing more trauma-informed approaches to customer engagement.

While these developments represent an important shift, comparatively less attention has been directed towards the emotional impact this work can have on the employees providing that support. Repeated exposure to customer distress, conflict, grief, financial crisis and emotionally demanding interactions may contribute to emotional exhaustion, compassion fatigue, burnout and other psychosocial hazards if appropriate organisational supports are not in place. At the same time, many employees report feeling pressure to remain composed, maintain professionalism and continue delivering high-quality customer service regardless of their own emotional wellbeing.

Recognising and responding to these challenges requires more than individual resilience. It requires organisations to develop capability that supports both compassionate customer interactions and psychologically healthier workplaces. Trauma-informed capability building provides one practical approach by equipping employees and leaders with a deeper understanding of trauma, emotional regulation, communication, reflective practice and strategies that promote both customer care and employee wellbeing.

This Practice Insight contributes to that conversation by sharing recurring observations emerging from trauma-informed capability-building workshops delivered within Australian financial services. Rather than focusing solely on customer outcomes, it highlights the lived experiences of employees themselves and explores what these observations may suggest for organisations seeking to strengthen both workforce wellbeing and organisational capability.

FIVE PRACTICE INSIGHTS

from Australian Financial Services

What we're hearing from financial professionals supporting customers through crisis.

1



WE HIDE IT BECAUSE IT'S PART OF THE JOB

Emotional labour is normalised in financial services. Many professionals feel pressure to stay professional, positive and composed—even when they're struggling inside.



Customers see our calm. They don't see what it takes to keep it together.

2



THE WEIGHT OF HELPING OTHERS IS REAL

Hearing stories of hardship, trauma, violence, grief and loss every day takes a toll. Over time, this contributes to compassion fatigue, vicarious trauma and burnout.



It's not just a difficult day—it's the ongoing cumulative impact.

3



WE FEEL GUILTY WHEN WE PUT OURSELVES FIRST

Many professionals struggle with guilt around rest and recovery. They feel they should be doing more, supporting more, or prioritising customers over their own wellbeing.



Rest feels uncomfortable—like we're letting our team or customers down.

4



THE EMOTIONAL LOAD FOLLOWS US HOME

The impact of our work doesn't end when the day does. It shows up in our homes, relationships and health—through poor sleep, irritability, helplessness and emotional exhaustion.



We carry stories we can't close and emotions we can't switch off.

5



TEAM SUPPORT MAKES ALL THE DIFFERENCE

Peer support, understanding leaders and psychologically safer workplaces help us process, recover and stay connected to purpose.



We can't do this work alone. Support helps us keep showing up for others.



Who supports the people supporting everyone else?

Supporting our workforce is essential to supporting our customers.

WHAT ORGANISATIONS CAN DO



Create space for reflection

Normalize conversations about the emotional impact of the work.



Build supportive teams

Encourage peer support and regular check-ins.



Prioritise wellbeing without guilt

Model that rest and recovery are part of professional practice.



Invest in trauma-informed capability

Strengthen skills, confidence and psychological safety.



Measure what matters

Include wellbeing, retention and team climate in your metrics.

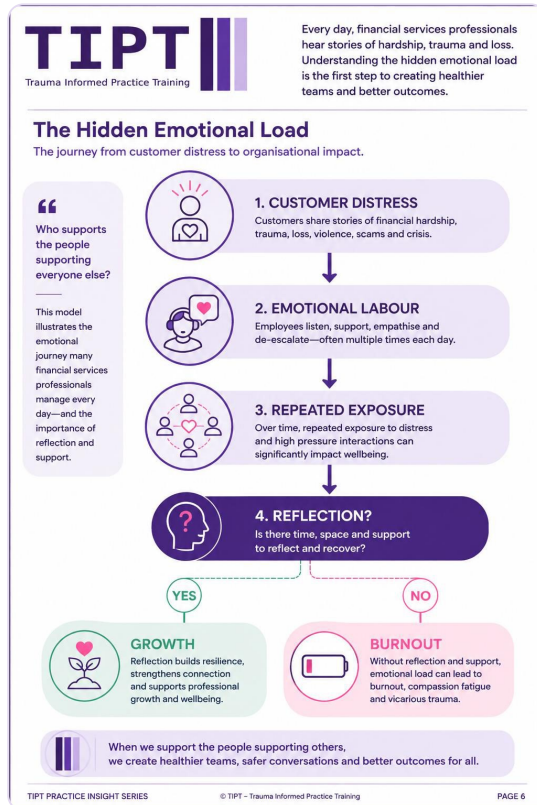
When we support the people supporting others, we create healthier teams, safer conversations and better outcomes for all.



03 · A PRACTICE MODEL

Understanding the Hidden Emotional Load

Every day, financial services professionals hear stories of financial hardship, family violence, bereavement, scams, homelessness and crisis. While organisations rightly focus on supporting vulnerable customers, the emotional impact of repeatedly hearing these stories is often less visible.



Emotional labour is not created by a single difficult conversation. It develops through repeated exposure to distress, the ongoing effort required to regulate emotions, and the absence of opportunities to reflect, recover and reconnect.

The model illustrates the emotional journey many financial services professionals manage every day — and the importance of reflection and support in determining whether that journey leads towards growth, or towards burnout.

When we support the people supporting others, we create healthier teams, safer conversations and better outcomes for all.

METHODOLOGY

Workshop Context

The observations presented throughout this Practice Insight emerged from trauma-informed capability-building workshops delivered within the Australian financial services sector. The workshops were designed using the **TIPT Trauma-Informed Framework™**, which integrates the principles of safety, trust, collaboration, choice, empowerment and cultural responsiveness into workplace capability development. Rather than focusing solely on knowledge acquisition, the workshops encouraged participants to actively explore workplace experiences, reflect upon emotionally demanding interactions and identify practical strategies for supporting both customer outcomes and employee wellbeing.

A central component of the workshops was the use of **LEGO® Serious Play®** as an experiential learning methodology. Through model building, metaphor and facilitated storytelling, participants were invited to represent complex workplace experiences that are often difficult to articulate through traditional discussion alone. This approach encouraged equal participation, reflective dialogue and collaborative learning while creating opportunities for participants to examine emotionally demanding work from a psychologically safer distance.

Participants explored a range of topics relevant to frontline financial services, including trauma-informed practice, recognising customer distress, emotional regulation, burnout, compassion fatigue, vicarious trauma, trauma-informed communication, wellbeing strategies, trauma-informed debriefing and practical approaches for maintaining psychological wellbeing while supporting customers experiencing adversity.

Throughout each workshop, participants shared the stories behind their LEGO® models, reflected on common workplace experiences and collaboratively identified practical strategies that could strengthen both individual wellbeing and organisational capability. Following each workshop, participant reflections, recurring metaphors, facilitated discussions and post-workshop reports were analysed to identify common themes emerging across the group.

The purpose of documenting these observations is not to evaluate organisational outcomes or establish causal relationships. Rather, it is to capture recurring practice-based insights that may contribute to organisational learning, stimulate professional discussion and identify opportunities for strengthening trauma-informed capability across the financial services sector.



Figure 1. Development of Practice Insights

From trauma-informed capability building to practical organisational insights



1 Trauma-Informed Workshop

Capability-building workshops are designed using the **TIPT Trauma-Informed Framework™** and delivered within financial services organisations.



2 LEGO® Serious Play® Activities

Participants use LEGO® Serious Play® to explore workplace experiences, challenges and strengths in a psychologically safer way.



3 Participant Stories & Reflection

Stories behind the models are shared, group discussions are facilitated and participants reflect on common experiences and insights.



4 Recurring Themes Identified

Facilitator observations, participant reflections and workshop reports are reviewed to identify recurring themes and patterns.



5 Practice Insights

Emerging themes are synthesised into practical, evidence-informed insights to inform organisational learning and professional discussion.



6 Implications for Organisations

Insights are translated into practical considerations to support trauma-informed leadership, employee wellbeing and organisational capability.



Learning from Practice.
Informing Capability.

TIPT Practice Insight Series

METHODOLOGY

Why Did These Conversations Emerge?

One of the most striking observations throughout these workshops was not simply what participants shared, but how openly they shared experiences that many had never previously discussed in a workplace setting.

Talking about sensitive topics can be very confronting for participants, so it is crucial that psychological safety and a third space is created for people to speak openly about what they are experiencing. Rather than asking participants to immediately answer questions about burnout, emotional labour or psychological safety, the workshops invited them to first build metaphorical LEGO® models representing their experiences.

WHAT PARTICIPANTS OFTEN TOLD US

- "I didn't realise everyone else felt like this."
- "I've never talked about this at work before."
- "I thought I was the only one."
- "I didn't know how to explain this until I built it."

Using LEGO® and building models, rather than personal disclosure, appeared to be an effective way to reduce defensiveness. The individual and group model builds created psychological distance between participants and the issues being explored. Because every participant built a model, everyone had an equal opportunity to contribute.

Stories were shared through the model rather than directly about the individual, allowing participants to describe complex emotions that many later reflected they would not have expressed during a traditional discussion.

As participants listened to one another's stories, common experiences became visible. Individuals who had believed they were struggling alone discovered that many colleagues were describing remarkably similar challenges.

The conversation gradually shifted from individual experiences to collective understanding. Rather than identifying isolated problems, participants began recognising recurring organisational patterns. The themes presented throughout this publication emerged through this process of shared reflection.

Why Did These Conversations Emerge?

Creating the Conditions for Deeper Reflection

These practice insights did not come from surveys or interviews. They emerged through a trauma-informed, LEGO® Serious Play® facilitated process that creates the psychological safety needed for real conversations.

FROM INDIVIDUAL THINKING TO COLLECTIVE UNDERSTANDING

THE POWER OF EXPERIENTIAL CONVERSATIONS

-  Everyone participates and contributes
-  Metaphor creates psychological distance and safety
-  Stories are shared through models, not directly about the individual
-  Judgement reduces, openness increases
-  Shared understanding emerges

**REAL INSIGHTS.
REAL IMPACT.**



TRADITIONAL DISCUSSION



VS

THIS APPROACH (TRAUMA-INFORMED LSP®)



Why LEGO® Serious Play® makes a difference

Building with LEGO® bricks activates imagination, allows metaphor, and engages both creative and cognitive thinking.

It helps people express what is difficult to put into words and creates the conditions for psychological safety, empathy and deeper listening.

These conditions are essential when exploring emotionally demanding experiences such as trauma, stress, compassion fatigue and workplace pressures.

What participants often told us

“ I didn’t realise everyone else felt like this. ”

“ I’ve never talked about this at work before. ”

“ I thought I was the only one. ”

“ I didn’t know how to explain this until I built it. ”



These insights emerged because people felt safe enough to be honest. When we create the right conditions for conversation, we create the opportunity for understanding, connection and meaningful change.

04 • FINDINGS

Emerging Themes

Introduction

Participants were invited to explore what compassion fatigue, burnout and the emotional demands of working within financial services looked and felt like through a series of LEGO® Serious Play® activities. Rather than responding to survey questions or discussing workplace experiences directly, participants constructed metaphorical models representing their experiences before sharing the stories behind their builds with the group. This process enabled participants to externalise complex emotions, identify common experiences and collectively reflect on the realities of supporting customers through highly challenging circumstances.

Although every model was unique, several recurring themes consistently emerged throughout the workshop. Many participants were surprised to discover that experiences they had previously believed were personal or isolated were, in fact, widely shared across their colleagues. These conversations highlighted not only the emotional demands of frontline financial services work, but also the importance of creating opportunities for reflection, shared understanding and psychologically safer workplace conversations.

The themes presented below do not represent research findings or organisational conclusions. Rather, they reflect recurring observations emerging from participant discussions and workshop reflections and provide insight into how financial services professionals described their lived experiences.

1

THEME 1

Behind the Professional Mask

One of the strongest themes emerging throughout the workshop was the perceived need to remain composed, resilient and professional regardless of the emotional demands being experienced internally. Participants frequently described feeling responsible for maintaining a calm and supportive presence for customers, even when they themselves were emotionally exhausted.

Several participants used powerful metaphors to represent this experience. Some described wearing a “mask” that concealed how they were really feeling, while others built models representing emotional walls, barriers or compartments that separated their professional role from their personal emotions. Some participants built themselves inside a box with no way to get out and spoke about their need to “shut themselves away from everyone else”. Others built a small LEGO® figure holding up cars or elephants to represent their feelings of being “overloaded” or “weighed down” by responsibility, while still trying to hold everything up or keep it together. These metaphors reflected a perception that vulnerability was something to be managed privately rather than openly discussed within the workplace.

Participants spoke about the cumulative impact of supporting customers experiencing financial hardship, grief, trauma and crisis while simultaneously managing performance expectations, service standards and increasing workloads.

“Sometimes customers tell me stories, and we get off the phone, break down and have a cry. Then get yourself together and get back on another call.”

Although many expressed a genuine commitment to helping customers, and wanting to support their teams and colleagues, they also acknowledged that maintaining this level of emotional regulation over prolonged periods could become increasingly difficult. Many groups noted that when things were becoming “too much” there was increased conflict within the team, isolation from each other and the pressure of trying to “keep everything together” was spilling out on their families at home. Many participants commented on their “short fuse” and noted an increase in conflict with their children and partners.



Figure 2 — Group build of what it looks and feels like when supporting others without replenishing themselves.

Interestingly, participants often reflected they thought they were the only ones feeling this way, only to discover through the LEGO® activities that many others were experiencing similar feelings of emotional exhaustion, uncertainty and overwhelm. The shared storytelling process appeared to normalise these experiences and reduce the sense of isolation that several participants described.

These observations highlight the emotional labour associated with frontline financial services work. While professionalism remains an essential component of customer service, the recurring metaphors suggest that employees may benefit from workplace cultures where conversations about emotional wellbeing are viewed as compatible with professionalism rather than inconsistent with it.

♥ **TIPT Reflection — Behind the Professional Mask**

WHAT PARTICIPANTS TOLD US

Many participants believed they were managing their emotional responses effectively until they discovered that colleagues were experiencing remarkably similar feelings of emotional exhaustion, overwhelm and isolation. The LEGO® activities appeared to normalise these experiences by creating opportunities for participants to discuss difficult emotions from a psychologically safer distance.

QUESTIONS FOR LEADERS

- If your team built a model representing how they really feel at work, what might it look like?
- What emotions do employees believe they need to hide in order to appear “professional”?
- How do leaders communicate that asking for support is consistent with professionalism?
- How confident are employees that they can say, “I’m struggling today”?
- What opportunities currently exist for emotionally honest conversations?

CONVERSATIONS TO TAKE BACK TO YOUR TEAM

- What does “keeping it together” look like here?
- What conversations aren’t we currently having?
- How do we recognise when someone is masking emotional exhaustion?
- What support would make the greatest difference to our team?

PRACTICE REFLECTION

Psychological safety is not demonstrated when people never struggle. It is demonstrated when people feel safe enough to say that they are struggling.

” Evidence in Context

“Emotional labour occurs when employees regulate their emotions to meet organisational expectations during interactions with others.”

— Grandey (2000, p. 97)

Participants’ descriptions of masking emotional exhaustion and maintaining a professional appearance despite feeling overwhelmed closely align with the concept of **emotional labour**. Financial services professionals are often expected to remain calm, empathetic and professional while supporting customers experiencing significant distress. Over time, this continual regulation of emotion may contribute to psychological strain, particularly when opportunities for reflection, support and recovery are limited.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Organisations cannot always remove the complexity of customer circumstances. They can, however, acknowledge the emotional weight of this work, provide opportunities for structured reflection, and equip leaders to recognise when compassion begins to shift from a source of professional satisfaction to a source of emotional exhaustion.

2

THEME 2

The Weight of Helping Others

Another recurring theme was the emotional weight participants associated with supporting customers through significant adversity. While many participants described their work as meaningful and rewarding, they also spoke about the cumulative effect of repeatedly engaging with distressing situations.

Participants described feeling overwhelmed by the volume and complexity of customer circumstances they encountered. Metaphors such as being buried beneath a growing pile of responsibility, carrying increasingly heavy loads or attempting to keep everyone afloat while struggling themselves reflected a perception that emotional demands accumulated over time rather than arising from single incidents. Some participants created builds which were a pile of bricks with them as a figure in front of the pile, showing them trying to remain calm but struggling to think clearly amidst the “chaos”. Other participants built themselves as a figure on a train track and showed the train holding multiple figures and animals, representing everyone else’s needs coming before their own, and them reflecting on the fact they would often “self-sacrifice” their needs for others. Other participants reflected on the weight of helping others as feeling like “a compassion merry-go-round”, that there were always more people to help, but that it was a never ending cycle.

“It feels like you are on a constant compassion merry-go-round. There are always more people to help, more problems and it just goes around and around.”

Financial Services Participant

Several participants also described feeling responsible for solving problems that extended well beyond their professional role. While recognising the importance of empathy and compassionate service, they reflected on the tension between wanting to help customers and recognising that many circumstances remained outside their control. This perceived responsibility often contributed to feelings of frustration, helplessness and emotional exhaustion. Participants built barriers, brick walls and blockages, all representing the frustration felt when coming up against policy, regulations or laws which prevented them from helping clients or customers in a way they would like. Some participants used the phrase “It feels like I am trying to do my job with my hands tied behind my back.”



Fig. 3a — Individual build representing the constraint of policy and process.



Fig. 3b — The ripple effect: "If one falls, there's a ripple effect."

Participants also identified a "ripple effect" within teams, noting that when one person became overwhelmed or required time away from work, remaining team members frequently absorbed additional workload, further increasing pressure across the group. This observation reinforces the importance of considering psychosocial hazards as organisational rather than purely individual issues. This was shown through LEGO® builds of figures lying on train tracks and capsizing boats, representing the emotional exhaustion, burnout and feelings of guilt for "making it more stressful for our teams because they are picking up our work."

♥ **TIPT Reflection — The Weight of Helping Others**

WHAT PARTICIPANTS TOLD US

Participants consistently described the emotional burden of supporting customers through highly complex and distressing circumstances while feeling unable to resolve many of the underlying issues contributing to those situations. Many reflected that they carried a strong sense of personal responsibility for helping others, even when organisational policies, legislation or limited resources prevented them from providing the level of support they believed customers needed. Rather than describing individual difficult interactions, participants spoke about the cumulative weight of repeatedly witnessing hardship, listening to distressing stories and navigating barriers beyond their control. Several described feeling as though they were “carrying everyone else’s problems” while attempting to remain calm, compassionate and professional.

QUESTIONS FOR LEADERS

- What emotional demands are placed on employees beyond their formal job descriptions?
- How often are staff required to absorb the emotional impact of customer distress while having limited ability to influence the outcome?
- Where might organisational policies or resource constraints unintentionally contribute to employee frustration or helplessness?
- How are managers supported to recognise the cumulative emotional weight carried by frontline staff?
- What opportunities exist for employees to reflect on difficult customer interactions before the emotional burden accumulates?

CONVERSATIONS TO TAKE BACK TO YOUR TEAM

- Which parts of our work feel emotionally “heavy”?
- What situations stay with us long after the customer interaction has ended?
- What barriers prevent us from helping customers in the ways we would like?
- What helps us let go of situations that are beyond our control?
- How can we better support one another when the emotional demands of our work begin to accumulate?

PRACTICE REFLECTION

Compassion is one of the greatest strengths employees bring to customer service. However, when compassion is repeatedly accompanied by helplessness, high workload and limited opportunity for recovery, the emotional weight of caring for others may become increasingly difficult to carry alone.

” Evidence in Context

“Compassion fatigue is a state experienced by those helping people in distress; it is an extreme state of tension and preoccupation with the suffering of those being helped.”

— Figley (2002, p. 1435)

Participants’ descriptions of carrying the emotional burden of customers’ experiences, wanting to help more than organisational systems allowed, and feeling overwhelmed by repeated exposure to distressing situations closely align with literature describing **compassion fatigue** and **secondary exposure to trauma**. While participants consistently described their work as meaningful and rewarding, many also reflected on the emotional cost of repeatedly engaging with suffering while having limited capacity to change the circumstances confronting the people they were supporting.

Several participants also described feeling constrained by legislation, organisational policy or available resources despite wanting to do more for customers. These reflections are consistent with the concept of **moral distress**, where individuals experience psychological discomfort when they know what they believe would be the right course of action but are prevented from acting because of external constraints (Jameton, 1984). Although originally described within healthcare, moral distress has increasing relevance across other helping professions where employees routinely navigate competing ethical, organisational and operational demands.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Organisations cannot always remove the complexity of customer circumstances. They can, however, acknowledge the emotional weight of this work, provide opportunities for structured reflection, and equip leaders to recognise when compassion begins to shift from a source of professional satisfaction to a source of emotional exhaustion.

3

THEME 3

Guilt Around Rest

One of the more unexpected themes to emerge throughout the workshop was the sense of guilt participants associated with taking time to rest, recover or prioritise their own wellbeing. Rather than viewing self-care as an essential component of sustainable professional practice, many participants described feeling conflicted about taking annual leave, accessing wellbeing supports or stepping away from work following emotionally demanding periods.

Participants working in financial counselling services described a constant awareness that demand consistently exceeded available resources. Many reflected on the emotional burden of supporting clients experiencing homelessness, severe financial hardship and other significant crises, while knowing there were many more people still waiting for assistance. Several participants spoke about feeling conflicted when considering their own wellbeing, explaining that their need for rest often felt insignificant compared to the urgency of their clients' circumstances. As one participant reflected, they finished each week feeling "completely shattered," while others described feeling "burned out" after repeated exposure to highly distressing stories. Some counsellors shared that hearing multiple accounts of people facing homelessness within the same week became emotionally overwhelming, leaving them in tears at work or requiring them to leave early to recover.



Figure 4 — Group build on what the team noticed when burnout was becoming more frequent: "Team trying to save" — "Other team members drowning."

Participants frequently spoke about the pressure to continue supporting customers and colleagues despite recognising their own fatigue. Several reflected that taking leave often resulted in increased workload for teammates upon their return or created additional pressure for colleagues while they

were away. As a result, many described feeling responsible for continuing to “push through” difficult periods rather than acknowledging their own need for recovery. Many participants completed builds with a never ending line of customers or clients needing their attention, and feeling like the line never got shorter.

The metaphors constructed during the LEGO® Serious Play® activities illustrated this tension in powerful ways. Some participants built models representing empty fuel tanks, constantly spinning wheels or structures gradually collapsing under increasing weight. These models reflected the perception that emotional resources could become depleted over time while opportunities for genuine recovery remained limited. One powerful metaphor comprised of a boat capsizing, and participants reflecting on their feelings of guilt for not being able to rescue other colleagues that needed it because they were too exhausted themselves.

Participants also recognised that this pattern was often reinforced by workplace culture rather than organisational policy. While many organisations actively encourage employee wellbeing, participants described an implicit expectation to remain available, resilient and productive, particularly during periods of increased customer demand or organisational change. The biggest focus for participants was often around the desire to protect the health and wellbeing of their colleagues and team mates, not wanting to place them under extra pressure when they needed time off.



Figure 5 — Team build of what burnout looks and feels like for their team: empty desks, rising sick leave, and a self-described “burnout jail.”

These observations highlight an important distinction between encouraging wellbeing and creating workplace cultures where recovery is genuinely supported. Sustainable performance depends not only on helping employees recognise the importance of self-care but also on fostering environments where taking leave (especially sick leave), accessing support and prioritising wellbeing are viewed as responsible professional behaviours rather than indicators of reduced commitment.

These observations suggest organisations may benefit from examining not only whether wellbeing resources are available, but whether workplace culture genuinely enables employees to access them without experiencing guilt or fear of burdening colleagues.

A PARTICIPANT'S STORY

One participant shared a story that remained with the group long after the workshop had finished. They described arriving at work during a period of severe burnout many years prior to their current organisation, explaining that they felt emotionally numb and disconnected from the customers they were supporting. They felt obligated to be at work and it hadn't occurred to them to take time off or sick leave because of the way they were feeling.

"I did my job. I answered every call. But I didn't feel anything. I had no empathy left."

At the end of that year, the participant was recognised as one of the organisation's highest-performing employees and received a significant financial reward for productivity. As they reflected on the experience during the workshop, they described feeling conflicted — rather than seeing the award as recognition of success, they viewed it as evidence that their organisation had measured productivity while remaining unaware of the significant psychological distress they were experiencing.

The group reflected on this important question: What if some of our highest-performing employees are also the ones who are struggling the most?

♥ **TIPT Reflection — Guilt Around Rest**

WHAT PARTICIPANTS TOLD US

Participants consistently recognised the importance of rest, recovery and self-care, yet many described feeling conflicted about prioritising their own wellbeing. Rather than viewing recovery as an essential component of sustainable professional practice, many reflected that taking leave or stepping away from work created feelings of guilt because they believed it placed additional pressure on their colleagues or delayed support for customers experiencing significant hardship. Interestingly, participants rarely described guilt arising from organisational expectations alone. Instead, many expressed concern about letting their colleagues down. Their reflections suggested that a strong sense of commitment to both customers and teammates often became a barrier to prioritising their own recovery.

QUESTIONS FOR LEADERS

- Do employees genuinely feel they have permission to prioritise their own wellbeing?
- What messages does your workplace unintentionally communicate about taking leave or stepping away from emotionally demanding work?
- How do leaders demonstrate that rest and recovery are essential components of sustainable performance?
- Are wellbeing initiatives focused primarily on individual resilience, or do they also address the organisational conditions that make recovery difficult?
- How are managers supported to recognise when dedication is becoming self-sacrifice?

CONVERSATIONS TO TAKE BACK TO YOUR TEAM

- What makes it difficult to take a break or use annual leave?
- What conversations occur when someone takes sick leave?
- How do we support colleagues returning after emotionally demanding periods?
- What does healthy recovery look like in our team?
- How can we create a culture where caring for ourselves is seen as supporting the team rather than burdening it?

PRACTICE REFLECTION

Sustainable workplaces are not created simply by encouraging employees to practise self-care. They are created when workplace cultures give people permission to recover without guilt, recognising that caring for themselves enables them to continue caring for others.

” Evidence in Context

“Recovery refers to the process during which an individual’s functioning returns to its pre-stressor level and the psychophysiological systems activated during work unwind.”

— Sonnentag & Fritz (2007, p. 205)

Participants’ reflections highlight the importance of recovery as an organisational, rather than purely individual, responsibility. While many recognised the value of self-care, they frequently described workplace cultures that made it difficult to disengage from work or prioritise their own wellbeing. Feelings of guilt associated with taking leave, working through lunch breaks and continuing to support others despite emotional exhaustion suggest that recovery was often viewed as secondary to meeting the needs of customers and colleagues.

Research consistently demonstrates that opportunities for psychological detachment, rest and recovery are essential for maintaining wellbeing and reducing the risk of burnout. When employees experience ongoing exposure to emotionally demanding work without adequate recovery, emotional exhaustion and reduced psychological wellbeing become increasingly likely.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Organisations cannot simply encourage employees to practise self-care while simultaneously rewarding constant availability and uninterrupted productivity. Creating psychologically healthier workplaces requires leaders to model healthy boundaries, support recovery and reinforce the message that taking breaks and accessing leave are not signs of reduced commitment — they are essential components of sustainable performance.



THEME 4

Emotional Spill-over Beyond Work

A recurring theme throughout the workshops was the difficulty many participants experienced in separating emotionally demanding work from their personal lives. Although participants described making conscious efforts to “leave work at work”, many acknowledged that interactions with distressed customers, unresolved situations and cumulative emotional demands frequently remained with them well beyond the working day.

Participants described continuing to think about customer circumstances after work, replaying difficult conversations or questioning whether they had done enough to help. Others reflected that emotional fatigue often affected their relationships with family and friends, leaving them with reduced emotional capacity to engage in activities they previously enjoyed.

“You go home and your fuse is so much shorter. Then you find that you just argue with your partner or kids.”

For participants working in community financial counselling services, emotional spill-over emerged as a significant theme. Many reflected that the emotional weight of supporting clients did not end when the workday finished. Instead, feelings of helplessness often remained with them long after they had left the office. Participants described replaying conversations, worrying about clients and questioning whether they had done enough to help. Despite investing significant time and emotional energy into supporting people experiencing severe financial hardship, some felt constrained by systemic barriers beyond their control. Two participants captured this experience through the metaphor of “driving into a wall”, explaining that despite their best efforts, progress often felt slow or impossible.



Figure 6 — Participant build showing the cumulative stress and trauma of the work day.

These reflections highlight the cumulative emotional impact of frontline financial counselling and the difficulty many participants experienced in separating the demands of their work from their personal lives. These metaphors may also reflect the emotional impact of working within complex legislative, policy and organisational systems where employees genuinely want to help but are constrained by regulations, procedures or limited resources. Across multiple workshops, participants repeatedly expressed a strong desire to do more for the customers and clients they were supporting but described feeling unable to provide the level of assistance they believed was needed. One participant summarised this experience by saying, "It feels like I'm doing my job with my hands tied behind my back."

This recurring reflection is significant because it highlights the emotional tension that can arise when professional values conflict with organisational or systemic constraints. While participants understood

the reasons for many policies and legislative requirements, they also described the distress of witnessing customer suffering while feeling unable to respond in the way they believed was right. These experiences are consistent with concepts associated with **moral injury**, where individuals experience psychological distress after being prevented from acting in accordance with their professional or personal values. Over time, repeated exposure to these situations may contribute to emotional exhaustion, compassion fatigue, vicarious trauma and other psychosocial risks if appropriate organisational support is not available.



Figure 7 — Participant build of the weight of carrying the trauma of others: a “fragile” parcel supported beneath a moving vehicle.

The LEGO® models frequently represented this spill-over through metaphors of carrying heavy loads, tangled pathways, overflowing structures and connections extending beyond workplace boundaries. These visual representations reinforced the perception that emotionally demanding work rarely remained confined to the workplace, instead influencing broader aspects of participants’ lives.

Importantly, participants did not describe these experiences as isolated incidents. Rather, they reflected on the cumulative effect of repeated exposure to emotionally challenging situations over extended periods. Many recognised that while individual customer interactions could be managed effectively, the accumulation of these experiences without structured opportunities for reflection or recovery created increasing emotional fatigue.

These observations reinforce the importance of recognising emotional labour as an ongoing occupational demand rather than simply responding to isolated critical incidents. Supporting employee wellbeing therefore requires organisational approaches that acknowledge the cumulative

nature of emotionally demanding work and provide opportunities for reflection, recovery and ongoing support.

♥ **TIPT Reflection — Emotional Spill-over Beyond Work**

WHAT PARTICIPANTS TOLD US

Participants consistently described the emotional impact of their work extending well beyond the workplace. While many made deliberate efforts to “leave work at work”, they acknowledged that emotionally demanding customer interactions frequently remained with them long after they had finished for the day. Rather than recalling isolated incidents, participants described a cumulative effect. Difficult conversations were replayed on the drive home, thoughts of vulnerable customers remained with them throughout the evening, and many questioned whether they had done enough to help. Several participants reflected that the emotional demands of work affected their relationships with family and friends, describing themselves as becoming less patient, emotionally withdrawn or more easily frustrated after emotionally demanding days.

QUESTIONS FOR LEADERS

- What emotionally demanding conversations are your employees having every day?
- How do you know whether employees are able to psychologically disengage from work at the end of the day?
- What opportunities exist for staff to process emotionally difficult customer interactions before they accumulate?
- Are managers equipped to recognise the cumulative effects of emotional labour rather than only responding to visible crises?
- How does your organisation acknowledge the emotional demands associated with supporting customers experiencing trauma, grief or financial hardship?

CONVERSATIONS TO TAKE BACK TO YOUR TEAM

- What types of customer interactions stay with us after work?
- What helps us genuinely switch off at the end of the day?
- How do we currently support one another following emotionally demanding conversations?
- What barriers prevent us from leaving work at work?
- What would help us recover more effectively before returning the next day?

PRACTICE REFLECTION

Emotionally demanding work does not end when employees leave the workplace. Sustainable organisations recognise that supporting recovery is not simply about helping people manage stress — it is about creating workplace cultures that acknowledge the cumulative emotional impact of caring for others.

“ Evidence in Context

“Recovery is the process during which an individual’s functioning returns to its pre-stressor level and the psychophysiological systems activated during work unwind.”

— Sonnentag & Fritz (2007, p. 205)

Participants’ reflections highlight the challenge of psychologically disengaging from emotionally demanding work. Many described continuing to think about customers, replay difficult conversations and carry feelings of frustration or helplessness long after leaving work. Research suggests that psychological detachment from work is an essential component of recovery, enabling employees to replenish emotional and cognitive resources between periods of work (Sonnentag & Fritz, 2007). When employees are unable to disengage, emotional exhaustion may accumulate over time, increasing the risk of burnout and reducing overall wellbeing.

Participants’ descriptions of wanting to do more for customers while feeling constrained by organisational systems also align with literature exploring **moral distress**. Jameton (1984) describes moral distress as occurring when individuals know the ethically appropriate course of action but are prevented from acting because of institutional or external constraints. Although originally developed within healthcare, the concept provides a useful lens through which to understand participants’ reflections about repeatedly encountering situations where compassion alone was insufficient to overcome systemic barriers.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Supporting employee wellbeing extends beyond helping people cope with difficult conversations. Organisations also need to create conditions that enable employees to recover from emotionally demanding work, recognise the cumulative impact of emotional labour and provide opportunities for structured reflection before emotional exhaustion begins to spill over into life beyond the workplace.

5

THEME 5

The Importance of Team Support

While participants openly discussed the emotional demands of frontline financial services work, they also consistently identified the protective role of supportive teams and psychologically safe workplace relationships. Across workshop discussions, participants repeatedly described connection with colleagues as one of the most significant factors contributing to their ability to manage emotionally demanding work.

“I’m so glad we have our team. When it’s hard, we know we can talk to each other.”

Participants also remarked on how much they enjoyed celebrating their wins with each other on the team and how much connecting with each other was crucial for their “drain off” and mental health.



Figure 8 — Team build of what helps them “drain off”: people, celebrating together, an open-hearted escape available.

Participants reflected that knowing they could debrief with trusted colleagues, share difficult experiences and receive understanding without judgement reduced feelings of isolation and helped normalise the emotional impact of supporting customers through adversity. Several participants described the simple opportunity to hear that others experienced similar challenges as both reassuring and validating.

“I felt so validated knowing I wasn't alone, that others felt the same way too. Maybe we don't have to keep masking to each other.”

Interestingly, many participants commented that the workshop itself created conversations that had not previously occurred within their teams. Through LEGO® Serious Play®, colleagues shared personal experiences, workplace challenges and perspectives that had often remained unspoken despite working closely together. Participants frequently remarked that they had gained a deeper appreciation of one another's experiences and recognised common challenges that had previously been invisible.



Figure 9 — Group build of what participants noticed in a team struggling with vicarious trauma: “feeling isolated + thinking everyone is coping” — “outwardly coping, but reality is not the case.”

These shared conversations contributed to a stronger sense of collective understanding. Rather than viewing emotional wellbeing solely as an individual responsibility, participants increasingly recognised the importance of creating workplace cultures where support, curiosity and open communication were embedded within everyday team interactions. Participants often expressed a genuine desire to become more mental health literate so that they could tackle some tougher conversations with any team mates who might be struggling.

As participants reflected on the practical mental health strategies explored throughout the workshop, many recognised that supporting their own wellbeing also required supporting one another. Several participants acknowledged that they routinely worked through their lunch breaks and reflected on the impact this was having on their own wellbeing. During the discussion, colleagues encouraged one another to prioritise taking regular breaks, joking that they would now “keep an eye on each other” and remind one another to stop for lunch. While shared light-heartedly, the conversation reflected a genuine commitment to creating a workplace culture where looking after one another’s wellbeing became a shared responsibility rather than an individual one.

The observations emerging from this theme suggest that organisational wellbeing is strengthened not only through individual resilience strategies but also through the quality of relationships between colleagues. Opportunities for structured reflection, shared learning and psychologically safer conversations may therefore represent an important component of trauma-informed capability building within financial services organisations.

♥ **TIPT Reflection — The Importance of Team Support**

WHAT PARTICIPANTS TOLD US

While participants openly discussed the emotional demands of supporting customers experiencing hardship, trauma and crisis, they also consistently described supportive teams as one of the most important protective factors for maintaining their own wellbeing. Across multiple workshops, participants reflected that simply knowing they had trusted colleagues they could talk to following a difficult interaction significantly reduced feelings of isolation. Many described the reassurance of hearing that others experienced similar emotional challenges, recognising that experiences they had previously believed were personal or unique were, in fact, shared across the team.

QUESTIONS FOR LEADERS

- How intentionally does your team create opportunities to reflect together rather than simply complete work together?
- When was the last time your team discussed the emotional impact of their work?
- How do you know employees genuinely feel supported by their colleagues?
- What opportunities exist for structured debriefing following emotionally demanding customer interactions?
- How do leaders role-model curiosity, openness and psychological safety during difficult conversations?

CONVERSATIONS TO TAKE BACK TO YOUR TEAM

- What helps you feel genuinely supported at work?
- Who do you turn to after a particularly difficult customer interaction?
- What conversations aren't currently happening that could strengthen our team?
- How can we better recognise when a colleague might be struggling?
- What small actions could help create a more psychologically safe team environment?

PRACTICE REFLECTION

Individual resilience is important, but participants consistently reminded us that wellbeing is rarely sustained in isolation. Supportive teams are built through everyday acts of curiosity, trust, shared reflection and genuine care for one another.

🗨 Evidence in Context

“Psychological safety is a shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking.”

— Edmondson (1999, p. 354)

Participants’ reflections strongly align with research demonstrating the importance of psychologically safe workplaces in supporting learning, collaboration and employee wellbeing. Many described feeling reassured after discovering that colleagues shared similar experiences of emotional exhaustion, highlighting the value of open dialogue in reducing isolation and normalising help-seeking.

The workshops also demonstrated how structured opportunities for reflection can strengthen collective understanding within teams. By sharing stories, listening to one another and collaboratively exploring workplace experiences through LEGO® Serious Play®, participants developed a deeper appreciation of the emotional realities faced by their colleagues. These observations are consistent with organisational learning theory, which suggests that learning is strengthened when individuals collectively reflect upon experience and develop shared understanding (Argyris & Schön, 1978).

WHY THIS MATTERS

Organisations cannot eliminate every emotionally demanding customer interaction. However, they can create workplace cultures where employees feel safe to talk about those experiences, seek support from colleagues and learn together. Investing in psychologically safer team relationships may be one of the most effective ways organisations can strengthen both employee wellbeing and sustainable performance.

05 · IMPLICATIONS

What These Themes Suggest

6.1 Emotional Labour is an Organisational Capability Issue

One of the strongest observations emerging from these workshops was that participants rarely viewed the emotional demands of their work as separate from their professional role. Supporting customers experiencing financial hardship, family violence, fraud, bereavement, homelessness and other highly distressing circumstances was consistently described as an expected part of everyday work rather than an occasional challenge. Remaining calm during difficult conversations, regulating emotional responses, demonstrating empathy and managing customer distress required significant psychological effort, often repeatedly throughout the working day.

Importantly, participants did not describe these demands as evidence that they were unable to cope. Rather, they reflected on the cumulative impact of continually providing emotional support while balancing legislative requirements, organisational expectations, performance targets and increasing customer complexity. Many described emotional labour as having a much larger component to their role than was acknowledged. It was fundamental to the service they provided to clients and customers, but it was much harder to quantify.

These observations suggest that emotional labour should not be viewed solely as an individual wellbeing issue. Instead, it represents an organisational capability requiring appropriate leadership, education and support. Just as organisations invest in developing technical capability, communication skills and regulatory knowledge, there may also be value in recognising emotional capability as an essential component of frontline financial services work.

Understanding emotional labour in this way shifts the conversation from asking individuals to become more resilient towards considering how organisations can better equip, support and protect the people undertaking emotionally demanding work every day.

6.2 Trauma-Informed Capability Building Supports Employees as Well as Customers

The workshops described throughout this Practice Insight were originally designed to strengthen participants' understanding of trauma-informed practice, managing burnout and vicarious trauma and improve interactions with customers experiencing vulnerability. While these outcomes remained central to the training, an unexpected observation consistently emerged across multiple workshops.

As participants explored trauma-informed approaches to supporting others, they also began reflecting on their own experiences of emotional exhaustion, compassion fatigue, burnout and workplace wellbeing. Conversations that initially focused on customer behaviour evolved into

discussions about participants' own emotional responses, workplace pressures and the cumulative impact of supporting people experiencing crisis.

This suggests that trauma-informed capability building may offer broader organisational benefits than are traditionally recognised. Rather than solely improving customer interactions, trauma-informed education appears to create opportunities for employees to better understand their own responses to emotionally demanding work, recognise early indicators of psychological strain and develop greater awareness of the support available within their teams.

The evidence-informed pillars of trauma-informed practice — safety, trust, collaboration, choice and empowerment — can be applied to all interactions with customers and clients experiencing high stress, grief, trauma and all kinds of vulnerabilities. They create a clear framework for how to best support people experiencing these hardships and, importantly, a clear framework and steps employees can take to provide that service in the best way possible. Trauma-informed practice creates clear boundaries for employees; they can finish an interaction and know they have done everything within their power to best support the client or customer, and hopefully, walk away feeling much less stress or guilt.

Equally important in this capability building was the way these conversations influenced team relationships. Participants frequently commented that they had developed a deeper appreciation of one another's experiences, recognised shared challenges and identified practical ways they could better support colleagues in the future. In this sense, trauma-informed capability building appeared to strengthen not only individual knowledge but also collective understanding, psychological safety and organisational learning.

These observations suggest that trauma-informed capability building may represent an investment in both customer outcomes and employee wellbeing, reinforcing the notion that supporting the people providing care is an essential component of delivering compassionate and sustainable services.

6.3 Psychological Safety Makes Hidden Work Visible

Perhaps the most significant observation emerging from these workshops was not simply what participants shared, but that they shared it at all.

Across organisations, many participants described experiences of emotional exhaustion, guilt, frustration, helplessness and self-doubt that had rarely been discussed within their teams before the workshop. Although colleagues often worked closely together, many reflected that they had little understanding of the emotional experiences occurring beneath the surface of everyday work. Several participants commented that they had assumed they were the only person struggling until they heard the reflections of others.

The use of LEGO® Serious Play® appeared to play an important role in facilitating these conversations. By encouraging participants to construct metaphorical models representing their experiences before explaining their meaning, discussions often became less about the individual and more about the story represented by the model. This psychological distance appeared to reduce

feelings of vulnerability while encouraging honest reflection, curiosity and dialogue among team members.

The observations presented throughout this Practice Insight suggest that many psychosocial hazards remain largely invisible until organisations intentionally create opportunities for people to discuss them. Emotional exhaustion, compassion fatigue, guilt and moral distress are not always apparent through productivity measures, absenteeism or formal reporting processes. Instead, they often emerge through psychologically safer conversations that enable employees to reflect openly on their experiences without fear of judgement.

For organisations seeking to strengthen psychosocial health and safety, these findings highlight the importance of creating structured opportunities for reflection rather than relying solely on reactive responses after problems become visible. Psychological safety does not eliminate emotionally demanding work, but it may increase the likelihood that employees will speak about their experiences before emotional strain develops into more significant psychological harm.

6.4 Reflection Creates Organisational Learning

One of the most consistent observations emerging throughout these workshops was that many of the most meaningful learning moments occurred not during the formal delivery of content, but during participants' shared reflection on their own workplace experiences. As colleagues listened to one another's stories, interpreted LEGO® models and discussed common challenges, participants frequently remarked that they had gained a deeper understanding of both themselves and the people they worked alongside.

Importantly, these conversations rarely focused on finding immediate solutions. Instead, they created opportunities for participants to make sense of emotionally demanding experiences that had often remained unspoken within their teams. Through reflection, participants identified recurring workplace patterns, recognised common emotional responses and developed a greater appreciation of the challenges their colleagues were navigating every day.

This observation reinforces the value of reflection as more than simply a learning activity. Reflection may also function as an important organisational capability, enabling teams to transform individual experiences into collective understanding. When employees are provided with structured opportunities to share experiences, challenge assumptions and learn from one another, organisations become better positioned to identify emerging psychosocial risks, strengthen communication and improve team cohesion before problems become more significant.

The workshops also highlighted that reflection contributes to organisational learning by making invisible work visible. Participants consistently identified emotional labour, frustration, guilt and psychological strain that had previously remained hidden behind professionalism and day-to-day operational demands. Once these experiences became visible, teams were able to discuss practical ways of supporting one another, improving communication and strengthening workplace relationships.

These observations suggest that creating regular opportunities for reflective dialogue should not be viewed simply as an employee wellbeing initiative. Rather, structured reflection may represent an important organisational process for strengthening learning, communication, psychosocial safety and continuous improvement within emotionally demanding workplaces.

6.5 Supporting Staff Supports Customers

A recurring message throughout this Practice Insight is that supporting employees and supporting customers should not be viewed as competing priorities. Rather, they appear to be closely connected — you can't do one without the other.

Financial services professionals consistently demonstrated a strong commitment to delivering compassionate, respectful and person-centred support to customers experiencing significant adversity. However, participants also described the emotional effort required to sustain these interactions over extended periods. They reflected on the cumulative effects of emotional labour, compassion fatigue, burnout, guilt and moral distress while continuing to meet organisational expectations and maintain high standards of customer service.

These observations suggest that organisations seeking to strengthen customer experience may also benefit from considering how they support the wellbeing of the employees delivering that experience. Employees who feel psychologically supported, connected to their colleagues, and equipped to manage emotionally demanding work may be better positioned to sustain empathy, communicate effectively and engage constructively with customers during difficult interactions.

Importantly, supporting employee wellbeing should not be interpreted as reducing expectations or lowering standards of performance. Rather, it recognises that sustainable performance depends upon creating environments where people have opportunities to recover, reflect, seek support, and continue developing the capabilities required for emotionally demanding work.

Trauma-informed capability building provides one practical mechanism through which organisations may strengthen both employee wellbeing and customer outcomes simultaneously. By increasing understanding of trauma, emotional regulation, psychological safety and supportive workplace relationships, organisations can build capability that benefits not only those receiving services but also those delivering them.

The observations presented in this Practice Insight suggest that emotionally demanding work will continue to be a defining characteristic of the financial services sector. As customer complexity continues to increase, organisations may find that investing in the wellbeing, capability and psychological safety of their people is not simply an employee wellbeing initiative — it is an investment in the quality, sustainability and effectiveness of the services they provide.



Trauma Informed Practice Training

WHAT ORGANISATIONS CAN DO **TOMORROW**

Five practical steps to support the people supporting others.

1



CREATE PSYCHOLOGICALLY SAFER CONVERSATIONS

- Encourage open, respectful dialogue.
- Listen with curiosity, not judgement.
- Normalise talking about the emotional impact of work.



START TOMORROW:
Ask one open question in your next team conversation.

2



BUILD REFLECTION INTO TEAM ROUTINES

- Build regular time to pause, check in and reflect.
- Debrief after challenging conversations.
- Make reflection a normal part of the work.



START TOMORROW:
Schedule 10 minutes in your next meeting for reflection.

3



SUPPORT LEADERS

- Equip leaders with trauma-informed capability.
- Support leaders to model wellbeing and boundaries.
- Provide leaders with supervision and peer support.



START TOMORROW:
Check in with a leader and ask how they are going.

4



RECOGNISE EMOTIONAL LABOUR

- Acknowledge the invisible emotional work.
- Show appreciation regularly and genuinely.
- Include emotional impact in workload conversations.



START TOMORROW:
Thank your team for the emotional effort they put in.

5



PROTECT THE PEOPLE SUPPORTING OTHERS

- Provide access to wellbeing resources and support.
- Respect rest, recovery and taking leave.
- Create a culture where people feel safe to speak up and seek help.



START TOMORROW:
Encourage someone to take a break they deserve.



When we support the people supporting others, we create healthier teams, safer conversations and better outcomes for all.

06 · CLOSING

A Final Reflection

Throughout these capability-building workshops, one message consistently emerged.

Financial services professionals care deeply about the people they support.

Participants spoke openly about the privilege of helping customers through some of the most difficult periods of their lives. They described the satisfaction that came from making a genuine difference to someone experiencing financial hardship, family violence, fraud, bereavement or other significant adversity. Their reflections demonstrated compassion, professionalism and a strong commitment to providing respectful and person-centred service.

At the same time, participants also described the emotional cost of this work.

Behind professionalism, many shared experiences of emotional exhaustion, compassion fatigue, guilt, frustration and helplessness. They reflected on carrying difficult conversations home, worrying about customers long after the workday had ended, and struggling with the tension between wanting to help more while working within legislative, organisational and resource constraints. Importantly, many believed these experiences were theirs alone until they discovered that colleagues were carrying remarkably similar emotional burdens.

Perhaps this is one of the most significant observations emerging from this Practice Insight.

The greatest value of these workshops was not simply that participants learned more about trauma-informed practice. It was that they were provided with a psychologically safer opportunity to pause, reflect and have conversations that had often never occurred within their teams before. Through shared reflection, participants discovered common experiences, developed greater understanding of one another and identified practical ways they could better support themselves, their colleagues and the customers they served.

The observations presented throughout this publication suggest that trauma-informed capability building may offer benefits extending beyond improved customer interactions. It may also strengthen organisational learning, team relationships, psychological safety and employee wellbeing by creating opportunities for people to better understand both the emotional demands of their work and the experiences of those working alongside them.

As customer complexity continues to increase across the financial services sector, organisations may wish to consider not only how they support people experiencing vulnerability, but also how they support the people responding to that vulnerability every day.

Ultimately, trauma-informed organisations are not defined solely by the compassion they extend to customers. They are also characterised by the compassion they demonstrate towards their own people.

Creating psychologically safer workplaces does not require organisations to eliminate emotionally demanding work. Rather, it requires a commitment to ensuring that those carrying the emotional weight of supporting others are themselves supported through leadership, reflective practice, trusted relationships and workplace cultures where asking for help is viewed as an act of professionalism rather than weakness.

The conversations documented throughout this Practice Insight leave one final question for organisations to consider.

If your employees were invited to build a model representing the emotional experience of working in your organisation today, what story do you think it would tell — and would your organisation be prepared to listen?

QUESTIONS FOR EXECUTIVE TEAMS

- What emotional labour is invisible in our organisation?
- Where do our people process difficult conversations?
- How do we know when compassion is becoming fatigue?
- Are our leaders equipped to facilitate reflective conversations?
- What would psychologically safer conversations look like here?
- If your team built a LEGO® model of their work tomorrow, what would it look like?

07 · EVIDENCE BASE

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